

KF38 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

Let's look at our prayer again in Nancy's alternative translation:

"Examine me, O God, and reveal my motivations. Run experiments on me and expose my misoriented thinking. See if there is any hurtful or idolatrous way in me, and lead me in eternal ways." (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

In this lesson we will focus on practicing the **Three-Part Breath** while relaxing the perineum and the face muscles. I will read instructions during most of the exercise. Practice this breathing method for a few minutes during your regular meditation time. By using our breath to engage the body, we practice pure *being*—a state in which we no longer need words, thoughts, images, or feelings to calm our anxiety. We allow our minds to cleanse and completely rest.

The Three-Part Breath

Assume a meditation posture and settle into your breathing. Observe how your body moves while it breathes. (*Pause for 30 seconds*)

The three parts of the body that we use in this meditation are the abdomen, the lower ribs, and the upper chest. As you inhale, first allow the abdomen to expand, then expand the lower ribs all the way round to your back, and lastly expand the upper chest under the collar bone. As you inhale, take in a consistent amount of air until you are filled to just below capacity. Stop and pause for two seconds, and then exhale. Practice inhaling in this way for thirty seconds. (*Pause for 30 seconds*)

Now when you exhale, first collapse the upper chest under the collarbone, then the lower rib cage, and lastly the abdomen. Keep your neck and face relaxed. It might help to maintain a little Mona Lisa smile throughout the exercise. Open the space between your eyebrows by relaxing the muscles on the sides of your face. Release any tension between the eyebrows or in the jaw. (*Pause for 30 seconds*)

During your exhale, try to keep the lower rib cage and abdomen expanded while the upper chest relaxes. Then, allow your lower ribs to deflate just before collapsing the abdomen. As you gently pull your abdomen toward your spine on the exhale, keep your perineum relaxed. Do not use your perineum muscles to help squeeze air out; use only your abdomen at the end of the exhale. (*Pause*) Before you

reach the end of your breath, stop exhaling and pause for two seconds, then slowly inhale again. Explore for one minute, stopping short of full or empty and pausing for two seconds at the end of each inhale and each exhale. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Notice how you feel during the pauses. What is happening inside your skin? Do you feel anxiety or frustration? *(Pause)* Is there an unwillingness to endure? *(Pause)* Do you need to adjust your breathing to honor your limitations? Just breathe and observe. You may wish to enjoy the pause as a cessation from all effort and a chance to dwell in the stillness of just being. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath. Now return to relaxed and quiet breathing as you observe what is going on inside your skin. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Open your eyes. Re-engage with your environment and the meeting. *(Pause)*

The **Three-Part Breath** massages your internal organs, pumps your lymph system, and mobilizes your cranial bones. Notice how breathing this way also stretches your thoracic spine and rib cage. Under the guidance of your will, you can train yourself to consciously breathe using more of your lung capacity, which allows your body to circulate more oxygen. Practice this breathing method for a few minutes during your regular meditation. As you become more proficient, you might practice for a longer time.

Our hymn for this confession is *O Love That Will Not Let Me Go*.

O Light that follows all my way,
I yield my flickering torch to Thee;
My heart restores its borrowed ray
That in Thy sunshine's blaze
Its day may brighter, fairer be.¹

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

God's purposes gain ground through KF Confession 9:

We learn to withdraw from the Idol Self and begin investing in our True Self.

In Karis Fellowships, we learn a variety of mindfulness and meditation practices and are introduced to tools that help us apply KF principles to our lives. The weekly teachings provide a Biblical basis for understanding the KF Confessions and KF concepts and culture. Our meetings connect us to the KF community and also provide an opportunity for healing. Healing is essential if we want to change our lives. Our choices and behaviors are often the result of hurt and damage, so if we want to live the glorious lives that God intends for us, we need to be healed.

For nearly nine months, you have been investing in your True Self by learning to use KF tools. You have been given a lot of information, and your toolbox is probably spilling over with tools that you don't use,

don't know how to use, or don't work for you right now. I hope that by regularly writing **Flow Pages** you will clarify for yourself what is working for you in Karis Fellowships and what is not working—and maybe even why. None of us can use all of the tools all of the time. Perhaps a tool will work for you next year that isn't working for you this year, or perhaps a particular tool works for you in one situation but doesn't meet your need in another. You may use some tools only occasionally, while other tools will become your default choice. When you use your tools to retrain and orient your soul, you invite the Creation to welcome you as one of God's creatures and to support you in your efforts to fulfill your potential. Together, you find out what will work for you today.

The tools of meditation and prayer are essential for maintaining orientation and connection. Choose a meditation practice that works for you and practice it every day for a month or for a year. You can use different practices in different situations, or you can combine practices. I use the **Lectio Divina** method when a Bible passage strikes me in a meaningful way. I use the **Maranatha Meditation** when I need to rest or focus, and if situations come up that shock or trouble me, I use the **SALT Process** or the **3-Minute Breathing Space**. When I am experiencing self-hate, the **Mercy Meditation** is my first choice, and I might then move to the **Self-Hate Massage**. Sometimes I use the **FAITH process** to explore and process an issue throughout the week. To feed my True Self from the Spirit of God, I use breathing and mental stillness. I keep my meditation toolbox open. I can always find something there that meets my present need.

When I am in a cycle of **Flow Pages**, I carry my notebook with me in case I have a few minutes to write. **Flow Pages** act like a mental drainage system. Through writing, I get “stuff” out of my mind and drain it onto the paper. Getting that stuff out helps stagnant energy start circulating again. Often while meditating, thoughts will nag and intrude, and I use **Flow Pages** to flush them out of my mind. When I wake up and before I go to sleep, I like to write for fifteen minutes, so I try to keep my notebook close by. **Flow Pages** help me tap into my creativity and think through my projects. They allow me to complain and to rejoice. I can write down anything, without judgment, because it's just words. While writing, I might even invent a fairytale, or I might suddenly understand how I can change my life.

You might find it tedious to use **Flow Pages** to explore what you really want, feel, and think. Writing takes effort and time; you have to slow down, and you may experience some self-hate. Your endurance in this process becomes a karis gift to God.

How would you respond to someone who shoots questions, opinions, and demands at you all day long, but never stops to listen, think, or even breathe? Rather than reducing prayer to the mindless and effortless comments that are often thrust at God throughout the day, you might make a conscious effort to record what you are really thinking. The process of writing trains you to focus, to endure, and to think about what you really want. Before making a decision, it's a great idea to stop and pray, but you might also want to stop and write.

You can use your **Flow Pages** as a way of talking to God. You can ask God a question or tell Him what is on your heart. Then you can mindfully write down what you think He might like to say to you. That would tell you a lot about who you think God is, wouldn't it? You might also write down what you think someone you trust might say to you. This isn't inspired Scripture. It is just a way of accessing latent wisdom that you may not know you have.

This week, use your **Flow Pages** to ask. Do you remember the lesson on A-S-K or Ask, Seek, Knock? In KF we also learn to think WAA!—Words, Attitude, Action. Use writing to speak your reality to God. Tell Him how you feel and what you think. Ask God to simplify and focus your life. Co-labor with Him by refusing

to overcomplicate your life or get caught up in old habits. Start purging your mind, your body, your relationships, your activities, and your environment. Try to identify anything that is left over from the days of your Idol Self. Use **Flow Pages** to help you figure out what to let go.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, I am ready to clean out my life. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

KF Confession 9 presents an important step in our healing.

We learn to withdraw from the Idol Self and begin investing in our True Self.

When people sign up for an immersion course, they immerse themselves in a language, a culture, and a way of life. Their primary goal is to become comfortable in a new way of living, as quickly as possible. Immigrants moving to another country are in that situation. They have often left a country of tyranny and oppression and are seeking peace and safety in a new land. They can either dive into learning new ways to live, or they can dawdle and resist learning and retraining out of judgment, fear, laziness, or ignorance. Which approach causes the most suffering in the long run, do you think? In KF, we are immersing ourselves in the better country of karis. Like immigrants, we are learning a new vocabulary, a new culture, and a new way of life. Learning new ways to live always involves suffering, but it is productive suffering. When, however, we dawdle and resist our training, our suffering is lengthy and fatiguing. We find ourselves in chronic self-hate but without the skills to deal with it, and we are torn by conflicting intentions that create a double mind. Perhaps worst of all, we build neuropathways of habitual resistance to further change or growth. Our pride system calcifies, and we find ourselves opposed by God and at odds with our created design. The Creation cannot support us because we have stepped out of the flow.

This is my translation of **Romans 6:1–11**, with a little paraphrase for clarity.

¹Are we to dawdle in misorientation, hoping to force God into giving us more karis gifts?

²Absolutely not! How shall we, the same people who are dead to misorientation, find life in misorientation? ³Don't you realize that anyone who has been immersed into Christ

Jesus has been immersed into His death? ⁴Therefore, we have been buried with Him through immersion into death so that we also might walk around in newness of life, just as through the splendid revelation of the Father's ability, Christ was raised up from those that are dead.

⁵Let me explain. If, like seeds in the ground, we have been planted together with Christ in the likeness of His death, it follows that like Him we will be raised in resurrection.

⁶Knowing this, that our old identity was crucified with Him so that the Idol Self—the whole body of misorientation—might be rendered entirely idle and without influence, and that we, having been liberated by that death, might no longer be forced to be the Idol's slaves living misoriented lives. ⁷Think of it this way. The one who has died has been set right—or freed from slavery to misorientation.

⁸If we have died with Christ,

we can confidently trust that we also will live with Him. ⁹Christ, having been raised from those that are dead, never dies again. We now understand that death is no longer master over Him, so we need no longer be enslaved by the fear of death. ¹⁰And not only this, the death that He died, He died once for misorientation, but the life that He lives, He lives continually for God. ¹¹In the same way, take into account that in the register of life you are entered as truly dead to misorientation and, in Christ Jesus, as continually alive to God.

Take a deep breath.

In Romans 6, Paul invalidates all of our excuses for not living in newness of life. If we continue to dawdle in misorientation, enslaved by our pride and the fear of death, it is our own fault if we suffer misoriented outcomes. And the scary thing is this: we can dawdle until we die. God will let us do that.

But there is an exciting possibility here. If you are in Christ, no matter how young or old, tall or short, rich or poor, or good or bad you are in this material world, and no matter what your background may be, you have the amazing potential of His resurrection life—and you are in the process of learning how His life can work through you.

My translation of Second Corinthians 5:17 goes like this: *“If anyone is in Christ, that person is a new creation. All that has happened before has passed on, and—look!—everything is new!”* (Repeat)

God invites you to experience the real glory of living in and exploring a whole new world of challenges and delights. With training, you can patiently cooperate with the Creator’s desire to resurrect your True Self into newness of life.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Creator and God, lead me to my resurrection. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume your meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider walking around in newness of life. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider walking around in newness of life*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to rest in your awareness as you *consider walking around in newness of life*. Observe whatever tension you may be feeling. *(Pause)* You might notice a compulsion to judge yourself, to push away or excuse thoughts or feelings, or to make up a virtue story. Give yourself permission now to explore without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider walking around in newness of life*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* You might notice what hope or lightness feels like in your body. You might feel pessimistic or ashamed. You might feel nothing at all. Gently maintain awareness of whatever your body is experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider the possibility of walking around in newness of life*. Is your experience right now pleasant, unpleasant, or vague and slippery? Just observe. *(Pause)* What do you believe when you consider walking around in newness of life? What story do you want to tell about that? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something—of yourself, of loss, or of others? Observe your experience as just information, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

For thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you feel when they have considered *walking around in newness of life*. You are not alone in your feelings. You are a human creature. *(Pause)* You can step back and learn from what you experience. *(Pause)* Breathe with compassion for all who are facing the challenge of a new life. Help your body process with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for drawing us together for healing. Hold us in the power of this new direction as You guide us to our glory and to newness of life. Lead us to the next step in letting go of our old ways of living as we cooperate with You to reorient toward Your design for our True Self and to declare the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

For the Christmas and New Year holidays, we will consolidate the regular Karis Fellowships meetings into two mega-meetings. This is a fun and interesting time when all the karis lifeboats link up and we hear voices from other groups. As always, every active KF member is welcome to attend.

*Registration for the spring NHG study is open. You and anyone whom you invite can register on the KF website or through the link on the invitation email sent out by KF admin.

*(*Except when preparing for the Jubilee Year)*

¹ *O Love that Will not Let Me Go* by George Matheson (1842–1906), www.youtube.com/watch?v=sxcnEBn1nA0,
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cejtlUBokdo&list=RDcejtlUBokdo&start_radio=1.